François Hollande), the French States has been unable to fully stem the tide of Islamist and antisemitic violence, which climaxed in the murderous assaults on the satirical magazine *Charlie Hebdo* and the Hyper-Casher Jewish supermarket in Paris in January 2015. The Socialist government, to its credit, has not returned to the evasive official mantras of the past. It recognizes that the many verbal and physical assaults in France have been directed against *French* Jews and *not* Israelis; it is also aware that such attacks have become almost routine on the streets, in the schools of the Republic, or in the Paris metro. The raw hatred has had a traumatizing effect on French Jewry. it followed the cold-blooded murders of Jews in March 2012 carried out by Mohammed Merah—a radicalized French-Algerian jihadi who had been trained in Afghanistan. Merah killed killed a young rabbi and shot dead three small Jewish children in Toulouse's Ozar Hatorah school at point-blank range. He even filmed himself in the act. Merah was a French-born citizen of Muslim background, who grew up in a family thoroughly imbued with anti-Jewish hatred.[11] Before that, there had been the sadistic murder of 23-year-old Ilan Halimi in 2006 on the outskirts of Paris by a gang named *Les Barbares* (the Barbarians) led by a French West African Muslim, Youssouf Fofana. The torture of Halimi, despite initial public and police denials, was undoubtedly an antisemitic act. The kidnappers had carefully selected a Jew in the expectation of extracting a large ransom from the Jewish community.[12]

On 24 May 2014, another French-born jihadist, Mehdi Nemmouche, who had returned from the killing fields of Syria, deliberately chose a high-profile Jewish target in Brussels. In an act reminiscent of Merah's "exploit," he opened fire with an assault rifle, killing four visitors in the Jewish Museum, situated in the capital of the European Union. The cumulative effect of these and many other less violent but deeply disturbing incidents suggests a grim prognosis for the furture of French and European Jewry. European Jews, especially in France, find themselves caught between the Islamist wave and the rise of far right populist-nationalists who did remarkably well in the last European elections in May 2014. The National Front (FN), led by Marine Le Pen, for the first time in its history came in first with over 25% of the vote—a striking success but not a very encouraging result for French Jews.[13] True, its present leader has clearly distanced herself from her father's notoious Holocaust denial, antisemitism, and racist Islamophobe rhetoric. But the FN ranks still contain more than their fair share of ultra-nationalists, racists, and fundamentalist Catholics. Moreover, the FN's allergy to the very idea of Jewish communal representation and its hyper-consciousness concerning Jewish opposition to its rise does not bode well. On the other hand, Marine

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